

MSc Creative Computing

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Practice as Research — Lecture 8

Critical framing — refining your argument

Mick Grierson — Creative Computing Institute, UAL

Black text on white. ~19 slides. Slide text lean; detail in the speaker notes.

Practice as Research

Critical Framing

Refining your argument

Lecture 8 of 8 — Practice as Research

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The whole arc

Weeks	What we built
1	Research = edge + hypothesis + test
2	How practice produces knowledge
3	Finding the gap
4	Choosing methods
5–6	Reflection and documentation
7	Exhibition vs research output
8	Tying it together into an argument

Today: how do all of these become **one coherent claim** that's meaningful for others?

From project to argument

You don't have a research project until you can state, in one sentence:

> *"I claim that X, because Y, as shown by Z."*

- **X** = your contribution (the new thing you know)
- **Y** = your reasoning (why it follows)
- **Z** = your evidence (artefact, documentation, study, analysis)

Everything you've made and written is in service of that one sentence.

The "So what?" test

Booth, Colomb & Williams (*The Craft of Research*) propose the most useful question in research:

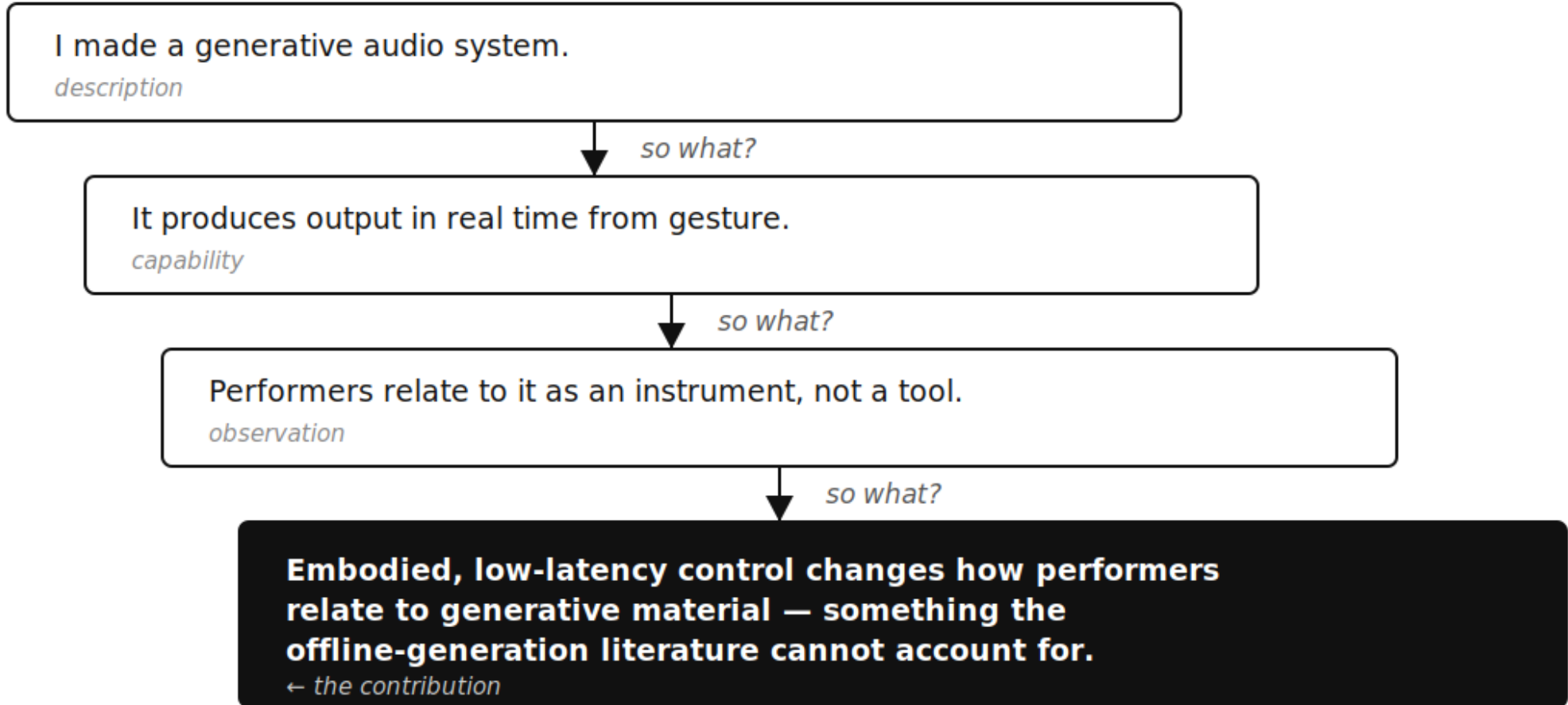
"So what?"

- I made a generative audio system. *So what?*
- It produces outputs in real time from gesture. *So what?*
- It shows that embodied, low-latency control changes how performers relate to generative material — a relationship the offline-generation literature can't account for. ← **there's the contribution.**

Keep asking "so what?" until you hit something the field would care about.

The “So what?” ladder

Keep asking until you reach something the field would care about



Each rung descends from what you did toward why it matters.
The bottom of the ladder is where the contribution lives.

The shape of an argument

Toulmin (1958) gives us the parts:

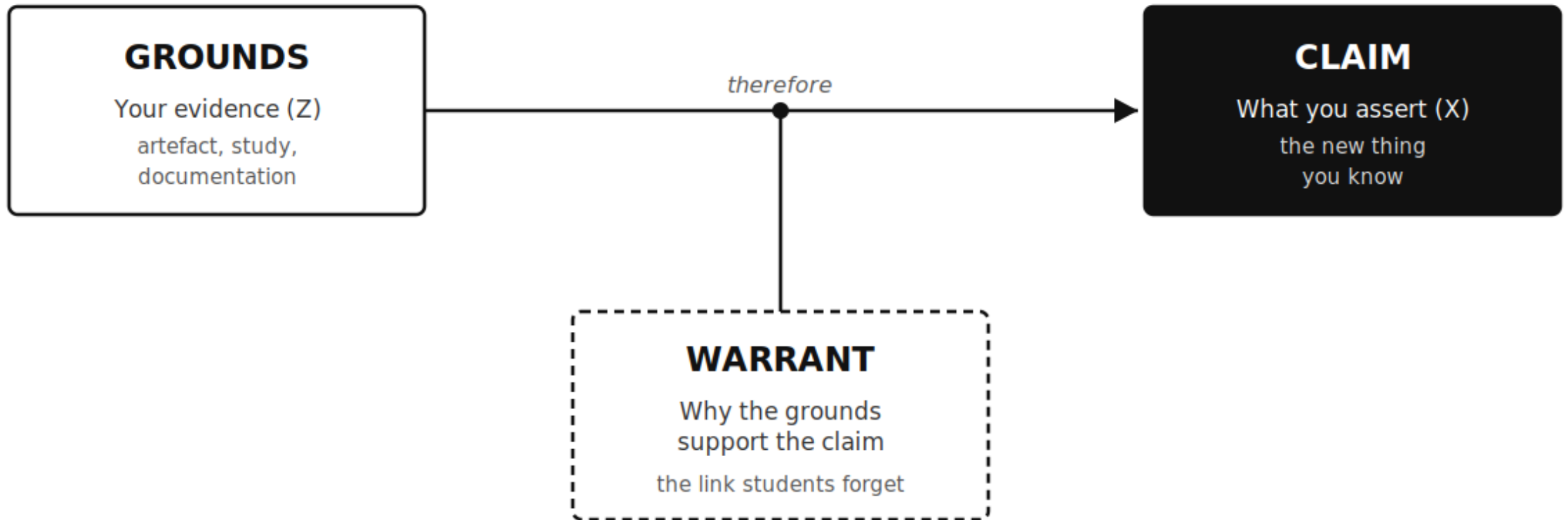
- **Claim** — what you assert (your X).
- **Grounds** — the evidence (your Z: artefact, study, documentation).
- **Warrant** — the link that explains *why* the grounds support the claim.

The **warrant** is the part students forget. It's the reasoning that connects "here's my evidence" to "therefore my claim holds."

The shape of an argument

Toulmin (1958)

The warrant is the reasoning that connects evidence to claim.
If it is shaky, the grounds do not actually support what you assert.



Synthesis is not summary

Bringing your work together is **synthesis**, not summary.

- **Summary:** "Here's what I read. Here's what I made. Here's what happened." (A list.)
- **Synthesis:** "These ideas, this making, and these results *together* point to something none of them shows alone." (A claim.)

Synthesis is the move from *components* to *contribution*.

Where your contribution comes from

Recall the five kinds of knowledge from Week 2. Your contribution usually lives in one or more:

- **Procedural** — a new technique or method
- **Experiential** — what it's like to encounter or use the work
- **Tacit** — embodied skill and judgement, made partly explicit
- **Propositional** — a testable claim
- **Critical** — a new way of framing a problem

Name which one(s) you're claiming. "My contribution is *critical and procedural*: a new technique, and a new way of thinking about what it's for."

Finding your voice

"Voice" sounds mystical. It isn't. Your voice is:

- the **questions** you find worth asking,
- the **connections** you see that others miss,
- the **stance** you take on what matters and why.

It emerges from your particular mix of skills, references, and obsessions. You don't invent it — you *notice* it, then sharpen it.

Voice is a position, not a style

Your voice isn't about flowery writing. It's about taking a **defensible position**.

Weak: "There are many interesting perspectives on generative music, and all have merit."

Strong: "The dominant framing of generative music as *automation* misses what matters: these systems are most interesting as *instruments*, not composers. My work proceeds from that position."

A position can be argued with. That's what makes it research.

Refining: the reverse outline

A concrete tool for tightening your argument:

1. Write your draft.
2. In the margin, summarise each paragraph in **one sentence** — what does it *claim*?
3. Read only the margin notes.
4. Do they form a logical argument? Or a list of topics?

If the margin notes don't flow, your argument doesn't either — no matter how good the prose.

Argue with yourself

A strong argument anticipates the strongest objection — and answers it.

Ask of your own work:

- What would a sceptic say?
- What's the most generous version of the opposing view?
- Where is my evidence weakest, and how do I handle that honestly?

Naming a limitation is a **strength**, not a confession.

A worked synthesis: from pieces to claim

Imagine the components of a finished project:

- **Gap:** generative audio is studied offline; real-time embodied control is under-explored.
- **Artefact:** a low-latency gesture-to-synthesis system.
- **Method:** construction + technical eval (latency) + 3 performers, interviewed.
- **Documentation:** process log, annotated portfolio, demo video.

The synthesis (the claim): *"Treating generative models as real-time instruments rather than offline composers reveals an embodied, dialogic mode of performance that the dominant offline framing cannot account for — demonstrated by a working low-latency system and performers' consistent reports of 'playing with' rather than 'using' it."*

One sentence. Every component earns its place in it.

A second example: a critical/curatorial claim

Not every contribution is a built system. Consider a project that is mostly *analysis through making*:

- **Gap:** text-to-image models are evaluated technically (bias benchmarks) but rarely interrogated *aesthetically* through sustained practice.
- **Practice:** a series of generated image-sets probing how models render contested subjects.
- **Synthesis:** "*Systematic artistic prompting functions as a research method that surfaces models' encoded assumptions in ways quantitative benchmarks cannot — the distortions are not noise but evidence.*"

The contribution here is **critical and methodological**, not a piece of software.

Reflecting on the process, not just the product

Your write-up should reflect on *how the work developed*, not only *where it ended up*.

- What did you believe at the start that turned out to be wrong?
- Which surprise changed your direction? (Your Week 5–6 notes hold these.)
- What would you do differently with another three months?

This is the iterative cyclic web (Week 2) made visible — and it's evidence of a researcher who learns.

Self-assessment: is your argument working?

Run your draft through these checks:

- Can I state my claim in **one sentence**? (Slide 3)
- Does it survive "**so what?**" (Slide 4)
- Is there a **warrant** linking evidence to claim? (Slide 5)
- Does my **reverse outline** flow? (Slide 10)
- Have I **answered the strongest objection**? (Slide 11)
- Is my **position** clear, not hedged into mush? (Slide 9)

If yes to all six, you have an argument, not just a project.

Common mistakes at the end

- **Describing, not claiming.** "Here's what I made" with no "so what?"
- **Burying the contribution** on page 30 instead of stating it up front.
- **Hedging away your voice** until no position remains.
- **Hiding limitations** instead of owning them.
- **Listing instead of synthesising** — seven components, no through-line.

Where this goes next

The argument you build here is the same shape you'll use for:

- a **conference paper** or journal article,
- a **funding application**,
- a **portfolio** or exhibition statement,
- a **pitch** for a job, a commission, or a collaboration.

"I claim X, because Y, as shown by Z" scales from a 60-credit project to a career.

The whole thing, in one breath

1. Find an edge (the gap).
2. Make something that investigates it.
3. Pay attention to what making reveals.
4. Document it so others can follow.
5. Decide what you now know that the field didn't.
6. Say it clearly, defend it honestly, and show your evidence.

That's practice as research.

References

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